

AP U.S. Government & Politics: The Complete Exam Guide

All 5 units explained, the required documents and Supreme Court cases, the four free-response question types, and 10 hard practice questions.

Hi, I'm **Pigo!** I'll drop tips all through this guide.



3 hrs

80 min multiple choice
+ 100 min free response

55+4

multiple-choice +
free-response questions

14

required Supreme
Court cases

72–76%

scored 3 or higher
in recent years

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01 THE EXAM AT A GLANCE

Two sections, one score

Your AP score (1–5) combines a multiple-choice section and a free-response section, each worth half. Both test how you apply concepts to new situations, documents and data.

50%

Section I • Multiple choice • 55 questions

50%

Section II • Free response • 4 questions

Exam structure

Section	Weight & timing	What you do
I • Multiple choice	50% of score 1 hr 20 min 55 questions	Individual questions and sets on quantitative data, text excerpts, visuals and Supreme Court cases. Apply concepts to scenarios and compare documents.
II • Free response	50% of score 1 hr 40 min 4 questions	Concept application • Quantitative analysis • SCOTUS comparison • Argument essay. Each is worth 12.5% of the exam score.

FULLY DIGITAL

Everything happens in Bluebook

You answer every question, including the written responses, in College Board's **Bluebook** testing app. Responses are submitted automatically at the end. Practice typing timed answers before May.

REQUIRED CONTENT

Know the documents and cases

The course has **9 required foundational documents** (such as the Declaration of Independence, the Constitution and Federalist No. 10) and **14 required Supreme Court cases**. They appear throughout the exam.

How to use this guide

Just starting?

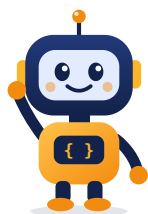
Read pages 2–6, then follow the roadmap on page 8 month by month.

Mid-year?

Check the traps on page 7 and drill the free-response playbook on page 6.

Exam in weeks?

Take the 10 questions on page 9 in 15 minutes, then use the final-four-weeks plan.



Pigo's tip: Government questions are rarely "what is X?" They ask how X **applies** to a new scenario. Practice explaining concepts with real examples.

SECTION I

02 The multiple-choice section

55 questions in 80 minutes gives you about 1 minute 27 seconds per question. Stimulus-based sets (graphs, excerpts, maps) take longer, so pace yourself.

55

questions, many based on a stimulus

~1:27

minutes per question on average

50%

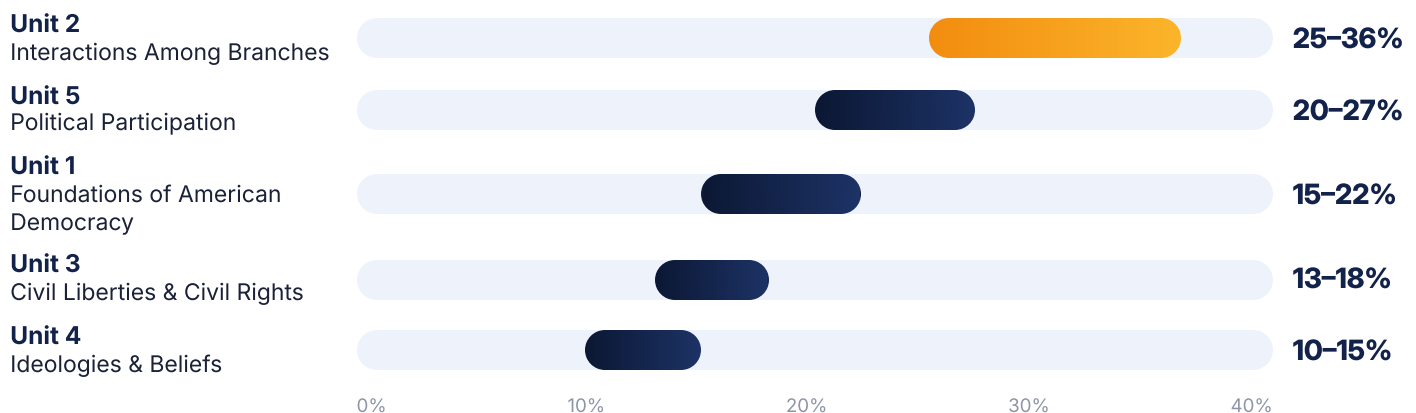
of your total AP score

0

points lost for a wrong answer, so never leave one blank

How the questions are weighted by unit

College Board gives a range for each unit's share of the exam. Bars show minimum to maximum.

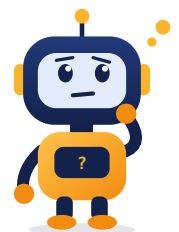


What this means for your study time: Congress, the presidency, the courts and the bureaucracy (Unit 2) make up about a third of the section. Political participation is the next biggest.

Strategies that work on this section

- Read graphs for the claim they support. Many questions ask what a chart shows, not what you think is true.
- Know each required case by its facts, the constitutional clause involved and the holding.
- Match the concept to the scenario. Is it federalism, checks and balances, or separation of powers?
- Watch the exact wording: "formal" (in the Constitution) vs "informal" (developed through practice) powers.
- Eliminate extreme answers with words like "always", "never" and "only".
- Flag and move on after 2 minutes. Return once the quick points are banked.

Know **which clause** each required case is about. That's often the whole question.



03 WHAT THE COURSE COVERS

The 5 units, in plain English

Everything on the exam fits into these five units.

UNIT

1

15–22%

Foundations of American Democracy

Where the Constitution came from and how power is divided.

Be ready to: explain popular sovereignty, limited government and natural rights; compare the Articles of Confederation and the Constitution; explain federalism, separation of powers and checks and balances; use Federalist 10 and 51, Brutus 1.

UNIT

2

25–36%

Interactions Among Branches of Government

How Congress, the president, the courts and the bureaucracy work.

Be ready to: explain congressional powers and procedures; formal and informal presidential powers; judicial review (Federalist 78, *Marbury v. Madison*); bureaucratic discretion and oversight.

UNIT

3

13–18%

Civil Liberties & Civil Rights

Rights protected from government and equal protection.

Be ready to: apply the Bill of Rights and selective incorporation; free speech, religion and press cases; due process; equal protection; the civil rights movement and Letter from Birmingham Jail.

UNIT

4

10–15%

American Political Ideologies & Beliefs

How people form political views.

Be ready to: explain political socialization; read and evaluate polls; compare liberal, conservative and libertarian ideas; link ideology to economic and social policy.

UNIT

5

20–27%

Political Participation

Voting, parties, interest groups, elections and media.

Be ready to: explain voting rights and turnout; the roles of parties, interest groups and the media; campaign finance (*Citizens United*); the Electoral College and election rules.

The 14 required cases are *Marbury v. Madison*, *McCulloch v. Maryland*, *United States v. Lopez*, *Engel v. Vitale*, *Wisconsin v. Yoder*, *Tinker v. Des Moines*, *Schenck v. United States*, *New York Times v. United States*, *Gideon v. Wainwright*, *McDonald v. Chicago*, *Brown v. Board of Education*, *Citizens United v. FEC*, *Baker v. Carr* and *Shaw v. Reno*. *Roe v. Wade* (overturned by *Dobbs*, 2022) is now taught in Unit 3, not as an FRQ 3 case.

SECTION II

04 The 4 free-response questions

100 minutes, 4 questions, each worth 12.5% of your score. The four question types are the same every year.

Q1 • Concept

Q2 • Data

Q3 • SCOTUS

Q4 • Argument

Each question is worth the same: 12.5% of your AP score

Q1

Concept application

~20 minutes

Read a scenario and explain how it connects to a political process, institution or behavior, then describe an effect or interaction.

Name the concept, then link it to a detail in the scenario.

Q2

Quantitative analysis

~20 minutes

Describe the data in a chart, identify a trend, draw a conclusion, and explain how it relates to a political principle.

Quote specific numbers from the chart; vague trends score less.

Q3

SCOTUS comparison

~20 minutes

Compare a non-required case you're given with one of the 14 required cases: the facts, the clause, and how the holdings relate.

Name the constitutional clause the two cases share.

Q4

Argument essay

~40 minutes

Take a position on a prompt, support it with two pieces of evidence (one from a foundational document), and respond to an opposing view.

Use a document from the list in the prompt; it's required for full credit.

◆ A time plan for the 100 minutes

Q1

~20 min

Q2

~20 min

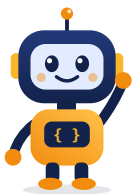
Q3

~20 min

Q4

~40 min

A suggested split, not a rule. Start with the question type you're strongest at, and never leave a question blank.



In the argument essay, the **rebuttal** is a separate point. Name an opposing view and explain why it's weaker.

05

FREE-RESPONSE PLAYBOOK

Anatomy of a strong argument

The argument essay follows a fixed rubric. Here is a practice prompt with a strong response, annotated.

PRACTICE TASK • WRITTEN BY ACT SAT GO

Practice prompt (Q4 style): Develop an argument that explains whether a large republic or a small, local democracy better protects against the dangers of factions. Use at least one piece of evidence from Federalist No. 10, Brutus No. 1 or the Constitution.

Sample argument (condensed)

- ① **Thesis:** A large republic better controls factions because it includes so many competing interests that no single faction can easily take over the government.
- ② In Federalist No. 10, Madison argues that a large republic "takes in a greater variety of parties and interests," making it harder for a majority faction to form and oppress others.
- ③ The Constitution adds separation of powers and federalism, so a faction that wins one branch or state still faces checks from the others.
- ④ Brutus argued that a large republic would be too distant from the people. However, elected House members and strong state governments keep citizens connected, so representation still works.

- ① **Thesis** takes a clear, defensible position with a reason.
- ② **Evidence 1** comes from a required foundational document.
- ③ **Evidence 2** adds a second, different piece of support.
- ④ **Rebuttal** names the opposing view and explains why it's weaker.

◆ Five habits for every free-response question

1

Answer each lettered part separately and in order.

2

Name the concept, then apply it to the scenario.

3

Quote numbers from charts; don't describe vaguely.

4

In SCOTUS questions, name the shared constitutional clause.

5

Stuck? Define the concept accurately; it can still earn a point.

06 LEARN FROM OTHERS

10 traps that cost points

Meet **Glitch**. He lives in these ten mistakes. Squash each one before May.

The Bill of Rights always applied to **states!** (It didn't.)



01 Incorporation confusion

The Bill of Rights originally limited only the federal government. Selective incorporation through the 14th Amendment applies most of it to states.

02 Formal vs informal powers

Formal powers are written in the Constitution (veto); informal ones developed in practice (executive orders, signing statements).

03 Liberties vs rights

Civil liberties protect individuals **from** government; civil rights protect against discrimination and ensure equal treatment.

04 Mixing up the case clause

Tinker is free speech; *Engel* is the establishment clause; *Yoder* is free exercise. Know which is which.

05 House vs Senate powers

The House starts revenue bills and impeaches; the Senate confirms appointments, ratifies treaties and tries impeachments.

06 Describing instead of explaining

"Explain" needs a how or why. Describing what happened is not enough.

07 Ignoring the chart

In Q2, answers must use the data shown, not general knowledge.

08 Missing the rebuttal

In the argument essay, responding to an opposing view is a separate rubric point.

09 Interest groups vs parties

Parties try to win elections and control government; interest groups try to influence policy.

10 Federalism terms

Categorical grants come with strings; block grants give states flexibility; unfunded mandates require action without money.

Quick self-check: how do *McCulloch v. Maryland* and *United States v. Lopez* differ in what they say about federal power? (McCulloch expanded it through the necessary and proper clause; Lopez limited the commerce clause.)

07

PLAN YOUR YEAR

Your study roadmap to May

A steady plan beats a last-minute rush. Shift the months to match your teacher's pacing, and review one required case or document every week.



Sep – Oct
Foundations



Unit 1

Founding documents, federalism and the Constitution. Make flashcards for the 9 foundational documents.

Nov – Jan
Branches



Unit 2

biggest unit

Congress, the presidency, the courts and the bureaucracy. Practice concept application questions.

Feb – Mar
Rights + beliefs



Units 3–4

Civil liberties, civil rights, ideology and polling. Practice SCOTUS comparisons with required cases.

April
Participation



Unit 5 + timed practice

Elections, parties, interest groups and media. Write timed argument essays.

Early May
Sharpen



Full timed sections

All four free-response types under timing. Review all 14 cases and 9 documents.

Exam day
May



AP US Gov exam • Bluebook

Sleep well, charge your device, and use the checklist at the end of this guide.

• The final four weeks

Week	Focus	Target
4 weeks out	Diagnose: 28 multiple-choice questions plus one argument essay	List your two weakest units
3 weeks out	Drill required cases and documents daily	Know the clause for every case
2 weeks out	Full 3-hour practice exam	Finish both sections on time
Final week	Light review: cases, documents, traps list	Rest the night before

08 TEST YOURSELF

10 practice questions

Original questions written by ACT SAT GO in the style of the exam, pitched at the harder end. Give yourself **15 minutes** for all ten, then check page 11.

1 UNIT 1 • FEDERALISM

In *McCulloch v. Maryland* (1819), the Supreme Court relied mainly on which constitutional provision to uphold the national bank?

- A The necessary and proper clause
- B The commerce clause
- C The Tenth Amendment
- D The supremacy clause alone

2 UNIT 1 • FOUNDATIONAL DOCUMENTS

In Federalist No. 51, Madison argues that liberty is best protected by:

- A a direct democracy in small states
- B a strong national religion
- C eliminating political parties
- D separation of powers and checks and balances, so "ambition must be made to counteract ambition"

3 UNIT 2 • CONGRESS

A bill passes the House but is changed in the Senate. What usually happens next?

- A The president signs the Senate version
- B The Supreme Court decides which version is valid
- C A conference committee or further votes reconcile the two versions
- D The bill automatically dies

4 UNIT 2 • PRESIDENCY

Which is an **informal** power of the president?

- A Vetoing legislation
- B Issuing executive orders
- C Serving as commander in chief
- D Granting pardons

5 UNIT 3 • SPEECH

Students wear black armbands at school to protest a war. Under *Tinker v. Des Moines*, the school can ban this only if:

- A the speech would cause substantial disruption of school activities
- B the protest is unpopular
- C the students are under 18
- D the war has been declared by Congress

6 UNIT 3 • INCORPORATION

Which case applied the Second Amendment right to keep and bear arms to state and local governments?

- A *Gideon v. Wainwright*
- B *United States v. Lopez*
- C *Schenck v. United States*
- D *McDonald v. Chicago*

08 TEST YOURSELF (continued)

7 UNIT 4 • POLLING

A poll of 2,000 people chosen from a website's visitors finds 70% support a policy. What is the biggest problem with this poll?

- A** The sample is too small
- B** The sample is not random, so it may not represent the population
- C** The margin of error is too small
- D** Polls cannot measure policy opinions

8 UNIT 5 • ELECTIONS

Which best explains why third parties rarely win seats in Congress?

- A** The Constitution bans third parties
- B** Third parties cannot raise money
- C** Winner-take-all, single-member districts favor two large parties
- D** The Electoral College selects members of Congress

9 UNIT 5 • CAMPAIGN FINANCE

The ruling in *Citizens United v. FEC* (2010) held that:

- A** corporations cannot spend money on elections
- B** limits on independent political spending by corporations and unions violate free speech
- C** all campaign contributions must be public
- D** only individuals can donate to candidates

10 UNIT 2 • COURTS

Which describes the principle established in *Marbury v. Madison*?

- A** Federal courts can declare laws unconstitutional
- B** Congress may override a Supreme Court ruling by majority vote
- C** States may nullify federal laws
- D** The president appoints justices without Senate approval

09

CHECK YOUR WORK

Answer key & explanations

Read every explanation, even for questions you got right. Each one points to a pattern that keeps coming back on the exam.

#	Answer	Why
1	A	Chief Justice Marshall held that the necessary and proper clause allows Congress to use implied powers, such as creating a bank, to carry out enumerated powers.
2	D	Federalist 51 argues that dividing power so each branch can check the others protects liberty.
3	C	Both chambers must pass identical bills. A conference committee or further votes reconcile differences before the bill goes to the president.
4	B	Executive orders are not listed in the Constitution; they developed in practice. The other powers are formal powers in Article II.
5	A	<i>Tinker</i> protects student symbolic speech unless it substantially disrupts school activities.
6	D	<i>McDonald v. Chicago</i> (2010) incorporated the Second Amendment through the 14th Amendment's due process clause.
7	B	Self-selected samples aren't random, so the results can't be generalized. Size doesn't fix bias.
8	C	Single-member, winner-take-all districts mean a party needs the most votes in a district to win, discouraging votes for smaller parties.
9	B	The Court ruled that limits on independent expenditures by corporations and unions violate the First Amendment, paving the way for super PACs.
10	A	<i>Marbury</i> established judicial review, the power of courts to declare laws unconstitutional.

9–10

Strong. Move on to full timed free-response practice.

6–8

On track. Revisit the unit behind every miss on page 4.

0–5

Build foundations now. Learn the 14 required cases and the 9 foundational documents first.

10 KNOW THE TARGET How students score

In recent years, about 72–76% of students earned a 3 or higher on AP United States Government and Politics, and about 23–24% earned a 5. Steady preparation is what moves a score up a full point.

72–76%

of students earned a 3 or higher in recent years

23–24%

earned the top score of 5 in recent years

3+

is the score many colleges accept for credit or placement

What each AP score means

5

Extremely well qualified

4

Very well qualified

3

Qualified

2

Possibly qualified

1

No recommendation

Ranges reflect recent College Board score distributions and shift a little each year. Credit and placement policies vary by college, so check each college's AP policy.

Exam-day checklist

- ☐ **Bluebook** is installed and updated, and your device passed the exam check
- ☐ Device **fully charged**, with the charger packed
- ☐ Admission ticket and photo ID, as your school requires
- ☐ Confirm your **exam day and start time** in May with your AP coordinator
- ☐ Plan your time: about **1.5 min** per multiple-choice question; **20 min** each for Q1–Q3 and **40 min** for the argument essay
- ☐ Answer **every** multiple-choice question. Wrong answers don't lose points
- ☐ Review the **14 required cases** and **9 foundational documents**
- ☐ Practice typing a full argument essay in 40 minutes

In the free-response section: name and apply concepts to the scenario, quote data from charts, identify the shared clause in SCOTUS comparisons, and include a rebuttal in your argument essay.



ACT SAT GO • 1-ON-1 AP TUTORING

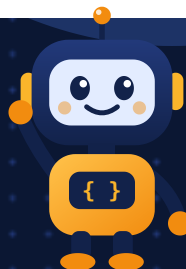
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Book a free diagnostic lesson →



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Concept tutoring

Live 1-on-1 sessions on all five units, with case and document drills.

Free-response coaching

Practice all four question types and get feedback against rubric-style criteria.

Timed exam practice

Full-length multiple-choice sets with score reports, so you see progress before May.

◆ Contact us

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